

Commentary on Psalm 66

Psalm 66

1. לַמְנַצֵּחַ שִׁיר מִזְמוֹר הָרִיעוּ לֵאלֹהִים כָּל־הָאָרֶץ:
For the leader. A song. A psalm.
Raise a shout for God, all the earth;
2. וַיִּמְרוּ כְבוֹד־שְׁמוֹ שִׁימוּ כְבוֹד תְּהִלָּתוֹ:
sing the glory of His name,
make glorious His praise.
3. אָמְרוּ לֵאלֹהִים מַה־נִּוְרָא מַעֲשָׂיו בְּרַב אֶזְרָה יִכְתָּשׂוּ
לִךְ אִי־יָהּ:
Say to God,
“How awesome are Your deeds,
Your enemies cower before Your great
strength;
4. כָּל־הָאָרֶץ יִשְׁתַּחֲוֶה לָּהּ וַיִּמְרוּ־לָהּ וַיִּמְרוּ שִׁמְךָ
סֵלָה:
all the earth bows to You,
and sings hymns to You;
all sing hymns to Your name.” Selah.
5. לָכוּ וְרֹאוּ מַפְעָלוֹת אֱלֹהִים נִוְרָא אֲעִלֶּה עַל־בְּנֵי
אָדָם:
Come and see the works of God,
who is held in awe by men for His acts.
6. הִפְךָ יָם לְיִבְשָׁה בִּנְהַר יַעֲבֹרוּ בְּרִגְלָם אֲשֶׁם נִשְׁמַחָה־
בּוֹ:
He turned the sea into dry land;
they crossed the river on foot;
we therefore rejoice in Him.
7. מִשָּׁל בְּגִבּוֹרָתוֹ עוֹלָם אֵינִי בַּגּוֹיִם תִּצְפִּינָה
הַסּוֹדֵרִים אֶל־[יְרוּמוֹ] (יְרִימוֹ) לָמוּ סֵלָה:
He rules forever in His might;
His eyes scan the nations;
let the rebellious not assert themselves.
Selah.
8. בָּרְכוּ עַמִּים אֱלֹהֵינוּ יְהִשְׁמִיעוּ קוֹל תְּהִלָּתוֹ:
O peoples, bless our God,
celebrate His praises;
9. הָשֵׁם גִּפְּשָׁנוּ בַחַיִּים וְלֹא־נָתַן לַמּוֹט רַגְלֵנוּ:
who has granted us life,
and has not let our feet slip.
10. כִּי־בִחַנְתָּנוּ אֱלֹהִים אֲצַרְפְּתָנוּ כְּצָרֶה־כֶּסֶף:
You have tried us, O God,
refining us, as one refines silver.
11. הִבַּאתָנוּ בַּמִּצִּידָה שִׁמָּת מוֹעֵקָה בְּמַתְּנֵינוּ:
You have caught us in a net,
caught us in trammels.

12. הִרְבַּבְתָּ אֲנוּשׁ לְרֹאשֵׁנוּ בְּאֵנוּ-בָּאֵשׁ וּבַמַּיִם
לְתוֹצִיאֵנוּ לְרִנָּה:

You have let men ride over us;
we have endured fire and water,
and You have brought us through to
prosperity.

13. אָבוֹא בֵּיתְךָ בְּעוֹלוֹת אֲשַׁלֵּם לָךְ נְדָרֵי:

I enter Your house with burnt offerings,
I pay my vows to You,

14. אֲשֶׁר-פָּצוּ שְׂפָתַי וְדַבַּר-פִּי בַצָּר-לִי:

[vows] that my lips pronounced,
that my mouth uttered in my distress.

15. עֹלוֹת מִיָּתִים אֶעֱלֶה-לָּךְ עִם-קֹטֶרֶת אֵילִים אֶעֱשֶׂה-
בָּקָר עִם-עֲתוּדִים סֵלָה:

I offer up fatlings to You,
with the odor of burning rams;
I sacrifice bulls and he-goats. Selah.

16. לְכוּ-שִׁמְעוּ וְאַסְפְּרָה כָּל-יִרְאַי אֱלֹהִים אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה
לְנַפְשִׁי:

Come and hear, all God-fearing men,
as I tell what He did for me.

17. אֵלִיו פִּי-קָרָאתִי וְרוּחַם תַּחַת לְשׁוֹנִי:

I called aloud to Him,
glorification on my tongue.

18. אֲנִי אִם-רָעִיתִי בְּלִבִּי לֹא יִשְׁמַע אֱלֹהִים:

Had I an evil thought in my mind,
the Lord would not have listened.

19. אֲכֹן שָׁמַע אֱלֹהִים הִקְשִׁיב בְּקוֹל תַּפְלִתִּי:

But God did listen;
He paid heed to my prayer.

20. בָּרוּךְ אֱלֹהִים אֲשֶׁר לֹא-הִסְרִי-תַפְלִתִּי וְחִסְדּוֹ
{פ} מֵאֵתִי:

Blessed is God who has not turned away
my prayer,
or His faithful care from me.

Introduction

Here is a psalm that opens by conscripting the entire planet — הָרִיעוּ לֵאלֹהִים כָּל־הָאָרֶץ, "raise a shout for God, all the earth" — and ends, twenty verses later, with a single throat: אֶשְׁרַע, "what He did for my soul." Somewhere between the cosmos and the larynx, the poem has performed a controlled collapse. The reader who notices this narrowing usually assumes the psalm simply lost its nerve, dwindling from grand public hymn into private testimony. The opposite is true. The shrinkage is the argument. Psalm 66 is built to prove that the reason all the earth *should* shout is that one worshipper's prayer was heard — that cosmic praise rests, at bottom, on a single answered petition, and that the individual who was rescued is the load-bearing wall of the whole edifice.

Before we watch it work, the floor plan. The psalm falls into two halves joined at a seam. The first half is communal hymn: a universal call to praise (vv. 1–4); a summons to see God's works in the splitting of the sea and the crossing of the Jordan (vv. 5–7); and communal thanksgiving for a national ordeal reframed as refining (vv. 8–12). Then, at verse 13, the grammar snaps from "we" to "I." The second half is individual thanksgiving: a lone worshipper paying vows at the Temple (vv. 13–15), and a summons to *hear* his personal testimony of answered prayer (vv. 16–20). Two summonses, two halves, one hinge.

The seam you can hear

The genius of the composition is that the seam is audible. Hebrew gives the poet two words that differ by exactly one consonant: תְּהִלָּה, "praise," and תַּפִּלָּה, "prayer" — *tə-hil-lā* against *tə-fil-lā*, a slide from *h* to *f*. The distribution across the psalm is total. תְּהִלָּה belongs entirely to the hymnic first half (v. 2 תְּהִלָּתוֹ, "His praise"; v. 8 קוֹל תְּהִלָּתוֹ, "the sound of His praise"). תַּפִּלָּה belongs entirely to the thanksgiving second half (v. 19 קוֹל תַּפִּלָּתִי, "the sound of my prayer"; v. 20 תַּפִּלָּתִי, "my prayer"). The two nouns even appear in matched phrases — קוֹל תְּהִלָּתוֹ, "the sound of His praise," in the communal section; קוֹל תַּפִּלָּתִי, "the sound of my prayer," in the individual one. The funnel from "all the earth" to "my soul" is not only grammatical; it is a one-consonant modulation from the *sound of communal praise* to the *sound of my private prayer*. The poet has tuned the seam.

And he has marked its stations with rests. The three Selah pauses (vv. 4, 7, 15) do not fall at random. Each one lands immediately before a plural command to an audience: Selah, then לָכוּ וּרְאוּ, "come and see" (v. 5); Selah, then בְּרַכּוּ, "bless" (v. 8); Selah, then לָכוּ וּשְׁמְעוּ, "come and hear" (v. 16). The musical breath is the intake before a fresh summons. Which is why the final movement, vv. 16–20, carries no Selah at all: the last call has already fired, and the testimony runs to its climax unbroken.

Seeing, then hearing

The two summonses are the poem's epistemology — its two ways of knowing God. לָכוּ וּרְאוּ, "come and see" (v. 5), points to the visible, public deeds of salvation history: הִפְךָ יָם לִיבֹשָׁה, "He turned sea into dry land" (v. 6). These are events anyone can look at, a spectacle in the sunlight. לָכוּ וְשִׁמְעוּ, "come and hear" (v. 16), points to something invisible — one man's account of what happened between him and God in private. You cannot photograph an answered prayer. You can only be told. The poem insists that both modes are needed: the sea-crossing is *seen*, but the salvation of a single soul must be *heard*, and only the two together make praise credible rather than theatrical.

This is why the audience narrows as it does — from כָּל־הָאָרֶץ, "all the earth" (vv. 1, 4), to עַמִּים, "peoples" (v. 8), to כָּל־יִרְאַי אֱלֹקִים, "all who fear God" (v. 16). Testimony requires listeners capable of receiving it. The hostile earth can be commanded to shout; only the God-fearing can be told the intimate thing and understand what they are hearing.

The refining and the ethics of being heard

At the center of the communal half sits a theology that refuses easy comfort. The ordeal is described as metallurgy: צָרַפְתָּנוּ כַּצָּרֶף־כֶּסֶף, "You refined us as one refines silver" (v. 10), the root צָרַף repeated within the line so that the verse is, so to speak, smelted by its own sound. Suffering here is framed not as punishment but as assay — controlled heat that removes the dross. The same God who split the sea is the God who heated the crucible; the net, the crushing weight on the loins, the riders over the head, the fire and the water (vv. 11–12) are all, grammatically, things God *did* — הִבֵּאתָנוּ, שָׁמַתָּ, הִרְכַּבְתָּ, "You brought us, You set, You made ride." The poet does not flinch from divine responsibility for the ordeal; he stakes the whole theodicy on the claim that the assayer intends purity, not destruction.

That same testing-vocabulary reappears, individualized, at the moral hinge of the second half. The God who assays a nation like silver (v. 10) also scans a single heart:

אֶן־אִם־רָאִיתִי בְלִבִּי, לֹא־יִשְׁמַע אֱלֹהִי

"had I seen iniquity in my heart, the Lord would not have listened" (v. 18). Here — and only here in the entire psalm — the divine name shifts from the pervasive אֱלֹקִים to אֱלֹהִי. The title אֱלֹהִי surfaces at precisely the moment the worshipper turns his attention inward, to the ethics of his own heart. The poem thereby refuses to let cultic performance stand alone: the bulls and rams of vv. 13–15 are worthless if the heart harbors אֶן. Prayer is heard because speech and interior align — and the poem's whole descent from planet to soul has been building to certify exactly that alignment.

The single insight to carry away: Psalm 66 does not shrink from the world to the self by losing energy. It funnels deliberately, because it is arguing that the ground of all cosmic

praise is one prayer that God actually heard — and the poet lets you *hear* the argument in the slide from תְּהִלָּה to תַּפִּלָּה, praise resolving, by a single consonant, into the answered prayer that justifies it.

Modern Jewish Liturgical Use

Full psalm

By the ruling of the Vilna Gaon (Maaseh Rav 194), Psalm 66 is the "Song of the Day" for the sixth day of Passover — a placement that reads the psalm's whole logic through its center. The sixth day leans toward the seventh, whose Torah reading is the splitting of the Sea; and the psalm's לִיבֹשָׁה יָם לְיַבֵּשׁ, "He turned sea into dry land" (v. 6), makes it the exact theological overture to that climax. The choice honors the *pshat* (plain sense): this is a psalm that grounds present rejoicing in the sea-crossing, and the calendar lets the community stand, liturgically, on the threshold of the miracle.

Key verses

The most widespread liturgical life of the psalm belongs to verse 9.

הַשֵּׁם נִפְשָׁנוּ בְּחַיִּים וְלֹא־נָתַן לְמוֹט רַגְלֵנוּ

"who has set our soul among the living and has not let our feet slip," is embedded nightly in the blessing of redemption after the evening Shema, אֱמֶת וְיִצְחוֹן. There it functions just as it does in the psalm — as the pivot from God's repayment of enemies to His positive preservation of Israel's life, immediately before the text turns to the paradigmatic redemption from Egypt. Recited across all major rites, and carried verbatim into the Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur *machzorim* (festival prayer books) (including Kol Nidrei night), the verse's language of preserved life and firm footing undergirds the community's nightly approach to the Amidah. In the Hasidic (Nusach Sefard) Simchat Torah *hakafot* (processional circuits), the same verse is woven into the petitions before the sixth circuit, associated with the sefirah of Hod (splendor) — a thanksgiving for the "standing" that lets the community dance without מוֹט, "slipping," before the Torah.

Phrases

The epithet נוֹרָא עֲלִילָה, "awesome in deed" (v. 5), was lifted out of its context and became a fixed divine title in piyyut (liturgical poetry), most famously as the incipit and refrain of Moshe ibn Ezra's Neilah hymn in the Sephardic and Edot HaMizrach rites:

קל נוֹרָא עֲלִילָה, הַמְצִיא לָנוּ מְחִילָה בְּשַׁעַת הַנְּעִילָה

"God awesome in deed, grant us pardon at the closing hour." The liturgy has quietly redirected the phrase: in the psalm the "awesome deeds" are acts of historical power that make enemies cower; at Neilah they become the awesome deed of *forgiveness*.

The scripted summons *אָמְרוּ לְאֱלֹהִים מִה־נִּוְרָא מַעֲשֵׂיֶיךָ*, "Say to God, 'How awesome are Your deeds'" (v. 3), recurs as a call-and-response cue in the Ashkenazic Yom Kippur Kedushah expansions of Shacharit and Musaf, where the *hazzan* (cantor) introduces catalogues of divine attributes with *אָמְרוּ לְאֱלֹהִים*. The psalm's imperative — a command to *others* to praise — is thereby turned into the congregation's own confession, precisely the move the psalm itself models when it hands the earth a script.

Verse-by-Verse Commentary

Verse 1

לְמִנְצָחַ שִׁיר מִזְמוֹר; הָרִיעוּ לְאֱלֹהִים כָּל־הָאָרֶץ:

The heading stacks two genre-labels, *שִׁיר מִזְמוֹר*, "a song, a psalm" — vocal lyric and instrumental piece named in one breath. The order here (song first) is the reverse of the more common *שִׁיר מִזְמוֹר* of Psalms 68, 87, and 92; whether the sequence signals a two-stage performance (sung lyric, then instrumental setting) is debated and probably unrecoverable, but the doubling itself suits a psalm that will insist on both *seeing* and *hearing* as complementary modes of worship.

The opening imperative is not a gentle invitation. *הָרִיעוּ* comes from the root *רוע*, whose native habitat is the battlefield. It is the shout at Jericho — *וַיִּרְיעוּ הָעָם תְּרוּעָה גְדוֹלָה*, "the people shouted a great shout" (Josh 6:20) — and the war-whoop of the Philistines running at Samson (Judg 15:14). When Psalm 98:4 pairs it with the identical universal object, *הָרִיעוּ כָּל־הָאָרֶץ*, "shout to the LORD, all the earth," it is summoning coronation-noise. So the psalm opens with victory acoustics, not concert manners: the earth is ordered to answer God the way conquered nations answer a king. The choice of *Elohim* rather than the Tetragrammaton is the fingerprint of the Elohist collection (Book II), where the divine name is systematically displaced — a fact that will make the lone *אֲדֹנָי* of v. 18 all the more conspicuous.

The phrase *כָּל־הָאָרֶץ*, "all the earth," sets the widest possible aperture in the first line — and, read against v. 16's contraction to *נַפְשִׁי*, "my soul," it already encodes the telescoping the whole poem will perform. The Septuagint's superscription adds *ἀναστάσεως*, "of resurrection," a word with no Hebrew counterpart; the addition, absent from the Masoretic Text, shaped much of the psalm's reception in the early Church, which read it forward from the death-to-life language of vv. 9 and 12.

Arrigo Boito, composing his opera *Mefistofele* (1868), opened with exactly this psalm's gesture — a universal choral acclamation demanding that the cosmos hail its Lord:

Ave, Signor degli angeli e dei santi!

Ave, Signor delle sfere erranti!

"Hail, Lord of angels and of saints! / Hail, Lord of the wandering spheres!"

Then Boito does what the psalm does not: he lets the enemy answer back. Mephistopheles cuts across the choir with dry apology — *Ave, Signor! Perdona se il mio gergo / si lascia un po' da tergo*, "Hail, Lord! Forgive me if my jargon leaves a little to be desired." The psalm assumes the shout is universal and coercive; Boito stages the one voice that stays unimpressed by the volume of heaven. The comparison sharpens what the psalm is claiming in v. 3 — that even the unpersuaded enemy is *forced* into the acclamation.

Verse 2

וַיִּמְרוּ כְבוֹד־שְׁמוֹ; שִׁימוּ כְבוֹד תְּהִלָּתוֹ:

Two cola (the line's two halves), and כְבוֹד, "glory," in each — כְבוֹד־שְׁמוֹ, "the glory of His name," then כְבוֹד תְּהִלָּתוֹ, "glory, His praise." The word means weight, heaviness, substance; here the repeated *k-v-d / k-v-d* loops the sound of the root through the line so that the ear feels the very heaviness the word names. The first colon has a close cousin in Psalm 29:2, הָבוּ לַיהוָה כְבוֹד שְׁמוֹ, "ascribe to the LORD the glory of His name" — but there the subject is YHWH; the substitution of Elohim here confirms the editorial layer of Book II.

The second colon's verb is unusual. Not "give" glory (נתן) or "ascribe" (הבו), but שִׁימוּ, "place, set" — as though glory were something installed, set in position, built into the act of praise. The Septuagint smooths this to δότε δόξαν, "give glory," normalizing the concrete Hebrew. Rashi hears the difficulty and offers two readings: וַיִּמְרוּ כְבוֹד שְׁמוֹ, "sing in honor of His name," or else סִפְרוּ כְבוֹד שְׁמוֹ בְּזִמְרָה וּבְשִׁיר, "recount the glory of His name with music and song." Ibn Ezra takes שִׁימוּ differently and more startlingly: בְּתִהְלָתוֹ תִּכְבְּדוּ, "through His praise *you* will be honored" — the praisers gain the weight they ascribe. The noun תְּהִלָּה, "praise," planted here, will recur at v. 8 to frame the whole hymnic half, before its near-twin תַּפִּלָּה, "prayer," takes over the second half.

Verse 3

אָמְרוּ לְאֱלֹהִים מַה־נֹּרָא מַעֲשֵׂיךָ; כָּרַב עֲזֶנְךָ יִכְחָשׁוּ לָךְ אִיְבֹיךָ:

The praise is scripted. אָמְרוּ לְאֱלֹהִים, "say to God" — the poet hands the earth its exact words, מַה־נֹּרָא מַעֲשֵׂיךָ, "how awesome are Your deeds." The exclamatory מה with נֹרָא (from

ירא, "to fear") will return in v. 5 as נִרְאָה עֲלֵיָהּ, so that the commanded confession here becomes something the audience is invited to verify there.

The second colon carries a verb with a barb in it. לִּפְנֵי אֹיְבֵיךָ יִכְתָּשׁוּ לְךָ does not mean the enemies genuinely worship. The root כחש here denotes deceptive, cringing submission — to feign, to lie-obey. The Septuagint catches it with ψεύσονται, "they will lie." The concordance shows this is a fixed idiom of forced foreign homage: בְּנֵי־נֹכַר יִכְתָּשׁוּ־לִי, "the sons of the foreigner cringe before me" (Ps 18:45), and Moses' blessing לִפְנֵי אֹיְבֵיךָ לֵךְ, "your enemies shall come cringing to you" (Deut 33:29). Rashi reads it as coerced confession: מֵרֹב פֶּחַד מוֹדִים, "out of great fear they confess." The theological point is precise, and the poem will exploit it: the enemies' submission in v. 3 is a *feigned* cringe, set in deliberate contrast to the *genuine* prostration of v. 4. There are two tiers of response to divine power — the coerced lie and the authentic worship — and the poet stratifies them across adjacent verses.

Verse 4

כָּל־הָאָרֶץ יִשְׁתַּחֲוּוּ לָךְ וַיִּזְמְרוּ־לָךְ; וַיִּזְמְרוּ שְׁמֶךָ סֵלָה:

Now the genuine article. יִשְׁתַּחֲוּוּ, "they bow down," is the verb of real obeisance, deliberately answering v. 3's feigned כחש: here כָּל־הָאָרֶץ, "all the earth," performs authentic prostration. And the phrase closes the inclusio — the envelope-frame — opened in v. 1: כָּל־הָאָרֶץ began the psalm shouting; it now ends the opening unit bowing.

The verb "sing" appears twice, and the repetition does real work by shifting its object. First וַיִּזְמְרוּ־לָךְ, "and they sing *to You*" — the person addressed. Then וַיִּזְמְרוּ שְׁמֶךָ, "they sing *Your name*" — now the name is the direct object, the content of the song, not merely its direction. Radak reads the universal scope eschatologically, quoting Zephaniah 3:9:

כִּי אֲנִי אֶהְפֹּךְ אֶל־עַמִּים שְׂפָה בְרוּרָה לְקַרְא כָּל־בָּשָׂר ה'

"then I will turn to the peoples a pure speech, that they all call on the name of the LORD." The first Selah falls here — the breath before the summons לְכוּ וּרְאוּ that opens the next movement.

Verse 5

לְכוּ וּרְאוּ מַפְעָלוֹת אֱלֹהִים; נִרְאָה עֲלֵיָהּ עַל־בְּנֵי אָדָם:

לְכוּ וּרְאוּ, "come and see" — the first of the two summonses that architect the psalm, deliberately paired with לְכוּ שְׁמְעוּ, "come and hear," in v. 16. Sight belongs to the public deeds of history; hearing will belong to private testimony. Both begin with "come," implying movement, pilgrimage, gathering to a shared event.

The divine epithet *נִרְאָה עֲלֵיָהּ*, "awesome in deed," rewards attention. *עֲלֵיָהּ*, from *עלל*, carries a striking range: it can mean simply "deed," but it also means "wanton act" or even "pretext, trumped-up charge" — as in Deuteronomy's *עֲלִילֹת דְּבָרִים*, "wanton accusations." The Septuagint renders it *βουλή*, "counsel, deliberate plan," pushing the sense toward *designed* action: God's deeds are purposeful, not random. Ibn Ezra defends the grammar carefully against those who would read the *ה* as a mere suffix meaning "exalted," insisting *נִרְאָה* is bound to *עֲלֵיָהּ*: "awesome in the deed." The singular (not plural *עֲלִילוֹת*) may intensify — awesome in *the* paradigmatic act, the deed about to be named. Rabbi Sacks reached for exactly this verse to name the terrible circuitousness of providence, commenting on Joseph's brothers and the descent into Egyptian slavery: "The script God writes for His people is sometimes circuitous and terrifying. The sages applied to it the pointed phrase 'How awesome is God in His dealings with mankind' (Ps. 66:5)." He heard in *נִרְאָה עֲלֵיָהּ* not comfort but the vertigo of a design one cannot see the shape of from inside it.

Verse 6

הִפָּךְ יָם לִיבָשָׁה; בִּנְהָר יַעֲבְרוּ בְּרִגְלָם; שָׁם נִשְׂמְחָה-בּוֹ:

This three-part line collapses time. The first verb is a completed past — *הִפָּךְ*, "He turned"; the second keeps the action open — *יַעֲבְרוּ*, "they cross"; the third pulls the speaker into the scene — *נִשְׂמְחָה*, "let us rejoice." History slides from *then* to *now*: the community does not merely recall the crossing, it *inhabits* it. The little word *שָׁם*, "there," pins the rejoicing to the ancient spot, and yet the verb around it pulls the scene into the speaker's present — we rejoice *there*, at what happened *then*. This is ritual recollection that makes the past present, the worshipper stepping into the salvation-moment.

The verb *הִפָּךְ* is more radical than "part." It means to overturn, transform, convert — God does not divide the sea but ontologically changes it into land, *יַבְשָׁה*, the exact word of the creation account (Gen 1:9) and of the Exodus (Exod 14:22). The *yam//nahar* pairing, "sea // river," carries an undertone from Canaanite myth, where Prince Yamm and Judge Nahar are the chaos-deities the storm-god must defeat. The psalm demythologizes them: they are not divine rivals but physical water Israel's God manipulates in historical time — the Red Sea (Exod 14) and the Jordan (Josh 3). Radak splits the reference cleanly: the sea is the Exodus, *בִּנְהָר* the Jordan crossing under Joshua.

The African-American spiritual "Wade in the Water" does to this verse what the verse does to the Exodus — collapses biblical time into an urgent present:

*Wade in the water, / Wade in the water, children, / God's gonna trouble the water. /
See that host all dressed in white, / The leader looks like the Israelite.*

Sung by enslaved communities, sometimes as coded instruction for escape along the Underground Railroad, the spiritual turns the crossing from a liturgical memory into a real-time survival strategy — the water not recalled but waded *now*. The psalm's נָשָׂם וְנִשְׂמָחָה, "there we rejoice," and the spiritual's imperative "wade" share a single conviction: the ancient crossing is not behind you but underfoot.

Verse 7

מִשָּׁל בְּגִבּוֹרָתוֹ עוֹלָם; עֵינָיו בְּגוֹיִם תִּצְפִּינָה; הַסּוֹרְרִים אֶל־יָרוּמוּ לָמוֹ סֵלָה:

From past deed to present rule. God is מִשָּׁל בְּגִבּוֹרָתוֹ עוֹלָם, "ruling in His might forever." The middle colon makes His governance surveillance: עֵינָיו בְּגוֹיִם תִּצְפִּינָה, "His eyes scan the nations." The verb צפה is not casual looking; it is the watchman's task — the reconnoitering from a raised post, as in Ezekiel's צִפָּה, "watchman" (Ezek 33:6). The plural verb with the dual "eyes" treats each eye as an independent sentinel. The point ties back to v. 3: the enemies cringe *because* they are watched; no rebellion goes undetected.

The final colon holds a textual crux. The written text (ketiv) is יָרִימוּ, a causative form that would mean "they raise up [something]"; the read tradition (qere) is יָרוּמוּ, the plain intransitive "they exalt themselves." The two stems assign different ambitions to the rebels: the ketiv could imply they try to elevate a rival power, the qere restricts them to mere self-exaltation. The qere fits הַסּוֹרְרִים, "the rebellious ones," better — self-exaltation is precisely what surveillance forbids. Rashi reads it as a hand held down: אֶל תְּהִי יָדָם רְמָה, "let their hand not be high." The archaizing suffix לָמוֹ, "for themselves," lends the warning solemnity. The root רוּם recurs at v. 17 in וְרוּמָם, the *legitimate* exaltation of God stored in the worshipper's mouth: self-exaltation is denied the rebel, God-exaltation fills the faithful. The second Selah closes the movement.

The middle colon's image of the all-scanning divine eye had a gentle afterlife. Civilla Martin's 1905 gospel hymn "His Eye Is on the Sparrow" keeps the concept of inescapable divine sight but shrinks its scale from hostile nations to a single bird — "His eye is on the sparrow, and I know He watches me." The psalm's gaze is an instrument of deterrence; the hymn's is a source of intimate comfort. Same eye, opposite emotional charge — the difference between being watched as a suspect and being watched over as a child.

Verse 8

בָּרְכוּ עַמִּים אֱלֹהֵינוּ; וְהִשְׁמִיעוּ קוֹל תְּהִלָּתוֹ:

The Selah has fired again, and here comes another summons: בָּרְכוּ, "bless." The addressees are עַמִּים, "peoples" — a broader, less political term than גוֹיִם, "nations" — and

they are told to bless אֱלֹהֵינוּ, "our God." The possessive is startling: outsiders are invited to bless the deity a particular community claims as its own. The tension does not collapse into either tribalism or bland universalism; it holds. Ibn Ezra records the debate directly — some take עַמִּים as the foreign peoples subject to Israel, "but others say עַמִּים means Israel," and he judges the latter נָכוֹן, "correct," comparing the archaic plural in Judges 5:14. The verb בָּרַכְו also opens a frame closed by בָּרוּךְ, "blessed," in the final verse (v. 20), bracketing the communal-to-individual arc with blessing.

The second colon commands broadcast: הַשְׁמִיעוּ, "cause to be heard, קוֹל תְּהִלָּתוֹ, the sound of His praise." This "sound of praise" is one pole of an acoustic pair the psalm will resolve at its climax — קוֹל תְּהִלָּתוֹ here against קוֹל תְּפִלָּתִי, "the sound of my prayer," at v. 19. Communal praise-sound and individual prayer-sound: the near-homophone (*tə-hil-lā / tə-fil-lā*) makes the one shade into the other by a single consonant, and the poem's whole descent runs along that slide.

Verse 9

הַשֵּׁם נַפְשֵׁנוּ בְּחַיִּים; וְלֹא־נָתַן לַמּוֹט רַגְלֵנוּ:

The reason to bless comes in an ongoing verbal form and a negation. הַשֵּׁם, "the One who sets," is an ongoing attribute, not a past act — God perpetually maintains us נַפְשֵׁנוּ בְּחַיִּים, "our soul among the living." The keyword נַפֵּשׁ is planted here in the plural, נַפְשֵׁנוּ, "our soul," and will contract to נַפְשִׁי, "my soul," at v. 16 — the single most load-bearing echo in the psalm, the collective life individuated into one.

The second colon supplies the psalm's most-recited line: וְלֹא־נָתַן לַמּוֹט רַגְלֵנוּ, "and He has not let our feet slip." The root מוֹט, "to totter," is the standard idiom for the collapse of life-security; Psalm 121:3 promises אֲלִי־יֵת לַמּוֹט רַגְלֶךָ, "He will not let your foot slip." Radak reads it as national survival in exile: God kept the community alive בְּאֶרֶץ הַגָּלוּת, "we were not finished off through the length of the exile." Malbim adds an inward turn — the ordeal produced repentance, so "He did not let our feet slip" from the path of God. Notice the body: the same feet that *crossed on foot* in v. 6 (בְּרַגְלִי) are now the feet *kept from slipping* — the poem tracks the community's journey through its own limbs, from the crossing to the crushed loins of v. 11.

Read against the psalm's own ending, this verse turns out to be half of a covenant-formula. The two ideas framing the second movement — feet not tottering (v. 9) and steadfast love not withdrawn (v. 20, וְחַסְדּוֹ מֵאַתִּי) — appear fused in a single line in Isaiah 54:10:

הַהָרִים יִמּוּשׁוּ וְהַגְּבָעוֹת תִּמְוָטֶינָה, וְחַסְדִּי מֵאַתָּה לֹא־יִמּוּשׁ

"the mountains may depart and the hills may totter, but My steadfast love shall not depart from you." What Isaiah compresses into one verse — stability of footing and permanence of *hesed* — Psalm 66 distributes across an eleven-verse frame. They are one covenantal thought.

Verse 10

כִּי־בִחַנְתָּנוּ אֱלֹהִים; צָרַפְתָּנוּ כַּצָּרָה־כֶּסֶף:

The opening כִּי, "for, because," makes this the theological ground of the thanksgiving: God kept us alive (v. 9) *because* He was purifying us, not despite the ordeal. Two metallurgical verbs, in careful sequence. First בִּחַנְתָּנוּ, "You assayed us" — בַּחן is the technical term for *testing* ore for its purity; then צָרַפְתָּנוּ, "You refined us" — צָרַף is the actual *smelting*. Assay, then smelt: the full sequence of the crucible.

The second colon performs its own metaphor. צָרַפְתָּנוּ כַּצָּרָה־כֶּסֶף — the root צָרַף appears twice, verb then infinitive, so that the comparison to silver-refining is enacted by the repetition itself; the line is, in a sense, smelted by its own sound. The imagery sits inside a prophetic tradition: Zechariah 13:9,

וְצָרַפְתִּים כַּצָּרָה אֶת־הַכֶּסֶף וּבִחַנְתִּים כְּבָחֹן אֶת־הַזָּהָב

"I will refine them as one refines silver and test them as one tests gold" — and, most pointedly, Isaiah 48:10,

הִנֵּה צָרַפְתִּידָּ וְלֹא כֶּסֶף, בְּחַרְתִּידָּ בְּכֹור עֲנִי

"behold, I have refined you, but not as silver; I have tested you in the furnace of affliction." Ancient Levantine cupellation demanded intense heat, the assayer oxidizing away the lead until the silver's surface mirrored his own face. Rashi captures the point exactly: refining removes the dross לְפָנֶיךָ בְּתַשׁוּבָה, "so that we return to You in repentance." Suffering is reframed as purposeful, not punitive — the community is not destroyed but brought to value. The same assaying verb, בַּחן, elsewhere takes the *heart* as its object — וּבָחֹן לְבוֹת ה', "and the LORD tests hearts" (Prov 17:3) — which is precisely the direction the psalm will turn in v. 18: the God who assays a nation like silver also scans an individual's לֵב for iniquity.

Verse 11

הֵבֵאתָנוּ בְּמִצְוֶדָה; שָׁמָּה מוֹעֵקָה בְּמַתְּנֵינוּ:

Now the ordeal in hunting-imagery, and God is the hunter. הֵבֵאתָנוּ בְּמִצְוֶדָה, "You brought us into the net." The word מִצְוֶדָה is genuinely double-edged: from צוּד, "to hunt," it means a

snare or net, but the identical form elsewhere means *fortress, stronghold* — precisely the refuge-word applied to God in Psalm 18:3, סֶלְעִי וּמְצוּדָתִי, "my rock and my fortress." The Septuagint resolves toward the hunt with παγίς, "trap." The ambiguity may be intended: God's protective stronghold, experienced from inside the ordeal, feels like a cage. Rashi glosses it כְּמִוּ בְּמֵאָסָר, "a narrow place, as in a prison"; Malbim, following the midrashic identification of the psalm with King Manasseh's Babylonian captivity, hears an actual jail.

The second colon holds a genuine hapax legomenon — a word occurring only here in the Bible. מוּעָקָה, from עוֹק, "to press, crush," means constricting pressure, and its target is לְשׁוֹן מְתַגְּבִינוּ, "our loins" — the seat of generative strength. Rashi files it under confinement: מִסְגֵּר, "a term of locking up." Malbim visualizes iron banding the waist so the prisoner cannot move. The Septuagint diverges on the body-part, reading "back" (νῶτον) rather than loins — a lighter image, mere burden-bearing, where the Hebrew attacks the source of vitality itself.

Clytemnestra, in Aeschylus's *Agamemnon* (458 BCE), gives the net-image its most chilling voice. Having murdered her returning husband, she describes the entangling robe she cast over him:

ἄπειρον ἀμφίβληστρον, ὥσπερ ἰχθύων,

περιστιχίζω, πλοῦτον εἴματος κακόν

"Round him, as if to catch a haul of fish, / I cast an impassable net, an evil wealth of robe."

The psalmist and the queen use the same figure — the inescapable net — to opposite theological ends. Clytemnestra's net is cold-blooded slaughter; the psalm's is a trial a loving God orchestrates as prelude to abundance. The juxtaposition measures the weight of faith the psalm's image demands: to be *caught in trammels* by God is to feel the helplessness of a hooked fish, and to trust the one holding the net anyway.

Verse 12

הִרְכַּבְתָּ אֲנוֹשׁ לְרֹאשׁוֹ; בָּאנוּ-בָּאֵשׁ וּבְמִיָּם; וַתּוֹצִיֵּאֵנוּ לְרִנָּה:

The theodicy at its boldest. הִרְכַּבְתָּ, "You caused to ride," makes God the grammatical subject who *let mortal men ride over our heads*. The word for the oppressor is אֲנוֹשׁ — the frailest term for humanity, weak mortal — so the irony is doubled: feeble men set as riders by God Himself. Rashi identifies them as מְלָכֵי כָּל אוֹמָה וְאוֹמָה, "the kings of every nation." The

image draws on Near Eastern victory iconography — the conqueror's foot on the neck of the vanquished (Josh 10:24).

The middle colon is a merism — totality named by two extremes. בָּאֵשׁ וּבַמַּיִם, "we came through fire and water" — every possible peril, the whole gamut. The Talmud (Berakhot 6b) reads it as a double judgment:

כְּאִלּוּ נִדּוֹן בְּשֵׁנֵי דִינִים אֵשׁ וּמַיִם

"as though sentenced by two ordeals, fire and water," and (Berakhot 5a's neighboring tradition) maps them onto Nebuchadnezzar's furnace and other historical crises.

Then the reversal, on a single vav-consecutive: וַתּוֹצִיאֵנוּ לְרִנָּה, "and You brought us out to saturation." The terminus רִנָּה, from רוּה, "to drink one's fill," is not mere relief but soaking abundance — the same word in Psalm 23:5, כּוֹסֵי רִנָּה, "my cup overflows." There is a deliberate water-arc: water was half the ordeal (בַּמַּיִם), and water-saturation is the redemption — the destroying element returns as the substance of rescue, exactly as the sea became dry land in v. 6. The Septuagint loses this, reading ἀναψυχή, "refreshment." A textual variant, supported by the versions, reads לְרִוְחָה, "to a wide place, relief" — which would trade the water-image for a spatial one but preserve the sense of release from constriction.

Claude McKay's sonnet "If We Must Die" (1919), written in the racial violence of America's Red Summer, refuses the psalm's posture at exactly this point:

*If we must die, let it not be like hogs
Hunted and penned in an inglorious spot,
While round us bark the mad and hungry dogs...
If we must die, O let us nobly die*

Where the psalm accepts having men "ride over our heads" as a divinely ordained, temporary humiliation on the way to rescue, McKay rejects the passivity of the hunted animal entirely, demanding resistance rather than theological patience. Reading them together clarifies what the psalm is actually asking of the sufferer: not defiance but a wager — that the one who let the riders mount will also bring the ridden through to saturation.

Verse 13-14

אָבוֹא בִּיתְךָ בְּעוֹלוֹת; אֲשַׁלֵּם לְךָ נִדְרֵי: אֲשֶׁר־פָּצוּ שְׁפָתַי; וְדַבַּר־פִּי בְצַר־לִי:

Here is the seam. Without a transitional word, the grammar snaps from communal "we" to singular "I": אָבוֹא, "I will enter." This is the sharpest cut in the psalm, and the commentators feel its force. Radak, Meiri, and Ibn Ezra all read the "I" as representative — Radak:

דָּבַר בְּלִישׁוֹן יָחִיד עַל לִישׁוֹן אֲנָשִׁי הַגָּלוּת בְּדֶרֶךְ כָּלֵל

"he speaks in the singular on behalf of the exiles collectively." Whether the "I" is a stylized everyman or a specific votary stepping out of the crowd, the effect is the poem's whole argument in miniature: the community contracts to one worshipper.

There is a directional overlay in the vocabulary. אָבוֹא, "I enter" (root בּוּא), is horizontal approach; the offerings are עוֹלוֹת, "burnt offerings" (root עָלָה, "to ascend"), which go vertically up. Worshipper and sacrifice cross at the Temple threshold. The verb אָשַׁלַם, "I pay/fulfill," shares the root of שָׁלוֹם/נְשָׁלָם, "wholeness" — paying a vow restores a completeness. The vow-payment idiom is standard: וְנָדַרְתִּי לַיהוָה אֲשַׁלֵּם, "my vows to the LORD I will pay" (Ps 116:14), and Jonah's from the fish's belly, אֲשֶׁר נָדַרְתִּי אֲשַׁלֶּמָּה, "what I vowed I will pay" (Jonah 2:10). The Talmud (Chagigah 7a) mines v. 13 for a legal distinction: how can a psalm invite entry "with burnt offerings" when Proverbs warns "make your foot rare in your neighbor's house"? — resolved by distinguishing obligatory sin-offerings from freely-brought burnt offerings.

Verse 14 specifies the vows' origin, and the verb is violent. פָּצוּ שְׂפִתַי, "my lips *burst open*" — פָּצָה is not the neutral "open" (פָּתַח) but a forcing-apart, the same verb used when the earth "opened its mouth" to swallow Korah (Num 16:30). Under crisis the lips are pried open near-involuntarily. And the crisis is named as narrowness: בְּצַר־לִי, "in my distress," from צָרַר, "to be narrow, pressed" — the individual's constriction reprising, in the first person, the community's מוֹעֵקָה, "crushing pressure," of v. 11. The seam at v. 13 joins the two ordeals rather than dividing them.

Flannery O'Connor's story "A Good Man Is Hard to Find" (1953) exposes the dark psychology the verse admits so plainly — that the vows were forged בְּצַר־לִי, "in my distress." The Misfit's verdict on the grandmother, who found grace only at gunpoint, is:

"She would of been a good woman... if it had been somebody there to shoot her every minute of her life."

The psalm celebrates vows made under extremity as valid and binding; O'Connor exposes the unnerving corollary — that it often takes the immediate threat of death to force a person into a posture of grace. The psalmist is honest about this in a way most liturgy is not: the mouth that will testify was first pried open by fear.

Verse 15

עֲלוֹת מִיָּחִים אֲעֹלֶה-לָּךְ עִם-קִטְרֶת אֵילִים; אֲעֲשֶׂה בָּךְ עִם-עֲתוּדִים סֶלָה:

An escalating sacrificial catalogue, and a conspicuous absence. מִיָּחִים, "fatlings," derives from מֶמֶךְ, "marrow" — animals so prime their marrow is rich; Rashi: נְשִׁמָּה, לְשׁוֹן מֶמֶךְ, "fat, from the word for marrow." Then rams, cattle, and עֲתוּדִים, "he-goats." Four premium categories — and no כֶּבֶשׂ, no ordinary lamb, the commonest sacrifice of all. The list points to abundance and status: cattle and fatlings, not the everyday sheep. The magnitude has fed the royal-authorship theories (Malbim's Manasseh, others' David); at minimum, the inventory suggests a wealthy votary.

The phrase קִטְרֶת אֵילִים, "the incense of rams," is unexpected. קִטְרֶת normally means *incense*, the aromatic smoke of the sanctuary; applying it to burning rams rather than the standard נִיחֹחַ, "pleasing aroma," makes the animal-smoke itself incense-like — the rams' ascending smoke becomes, in effect, ascending praise (recall עֲלוֹת, "what goes up"). The Septuagint collapses the categories entirely, rendering θυμίαμα, "incense," and losing the animal. The third and final Selah closes the cultic movement; Metzudat David reads it as eternity — לְעוֹלָם מִבְּלִי הַפָּסֵק, "forever without cessation," since the final Temple will not be destroyed.

Horace, in *Odes* 3.23 (c. 23 BCE), stands as the deliberate counter-voice to this maximalist slaughter. Addressing a farmer's daughter about votive offerings, he inverts the psalm's whole economy of value:

immunis aram si tetigit manus...

mollivit aversos Penatis / farre pio et saliente mica.

*"If an innocent hand has touched the altar... it appeases the hostile household gods
/ with pious meal and crackling salt, more persuasively than a costly victim."*

The psalm demonstrates gratitude through a kingly heap of bulls and rams; Horace insists a pinch of grain from a pure hand outweighs the wealthy man's blood. The two texts are not as far apart as they look — because the psalm itself, three verses later (v. 18), will subordinate the entire catalogue to the purity of the heart. Horace's *innocent hand* and the psalm's *iniquity-free heart* land in the same place: the sacrifice is only as valuable as the interior behind it.

Verse 16

לְכוּ-שִׁמְעוּ וְאַסְפְּרָה כָּל-יִרְאֵי אֱלֹהִים; אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה לְנַפְשִׁי:

The psalm's defining double contraction. The summons לְכוּ־שְׁמְעוּ, "come and hear," mirrors לְכוּ וּרְאוּ, "come and see," of v. 5 — but the sense-organ has changed. Cosmic history was *seen*; personal testimony is *heard*. You can behold a parted sea; you can only be *told* what happened in a man's prayer. And the audience has narrowed from כָּל־הָאָרֶץ, "all the earth" (v. 1), to כָּל־יִרְאַי אֱלֹקִים, "all who fear God" — the listeners capable of receiving testimony. Rashi reads them as הַגֵּרִים שֶׁיִּתְגַּיְרוּ, "the proselytes who convert" — the phrase יִרְאַי אֱלֹקִים need not mean ethnic Israel, and so the funnel is qualification by piety, not by blood.

The final phrase lands the keyword the psalm has been aiming at since v. 9: אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה לְנַפְשִׁי, "what He did for *my soul*." The plural נַפְשֵׁינוּ, "our soul," of v. 9 has contracted to the singular נַפְשִׁי, "my soul" — the collective life reduced to its irreducible unit. This is the poem's thesis made grammar: the individual nefesh *is* the corporate nefesh compressed to one, and the personal salvation authenticates the national one.

Rachel Bluwstein — the Hebrew poet known simply as Rachel, writing in the Yishuv in the 1920s as tuberculosis narrowed her life — addressed the very alchemy this verse assumes: raw crying turned into shaped testimony. But where the psalmist is confident, she is ambivalent:

צְרִיחוֹת שֶׁצִּרְחָתִי נוֹאֶשֶׁת, כּוֹאֶבֶת, / בְּשָׁעוֹת מְצִיקָה וְאֶבֶדָּן

הָיוּ לְמַחְרֹזֹת מְלִים מְלֻבָּבֶת, / לְסֵפֶר שִׁירֵי הַלֵּבָן.

"The screams that I screamed, desperate, in pain, / in hours of distress and loss, / became a charming necklace of words, / for my white book of poems."

The psalmist moves seamlessly from the crisis-cry of v. 14 (פָּצוּ שִׁפְתָּי, "my lips burst open") to the polished public testimony of v. 16, proud to *tell*. Rachel feels the same conversion as a loss — her desperate screams sanitized into a "charming necklace." Reading her against the psalm surfaces a question the psalm suppresses: what is spent when suffering is made into shareable speech? The psalmist answers by insisting (v. 18) that the telling is only legitimate if the heart behind it is clean — the aestheticized testimony must still be *true*.

Verse 17

אֵלָיו פִּי־קָרָאתִי; וְרוּמָם תַּחַת לִשּׁוֹנִי:

The first colon fronts the direction: אֵלָיו, "to Him," before the verb — "to *Him* my mouth called," the target emphasized over the act. The mouth (פֶּה) is the continuous instrument of the whole crisis-to-testimony sequence, from the lips bursting open in v. 14 to the telling in v. 16.

The second colon is spatially strange: *וְרוֹמָם תַּחַת לְשׁוֹנִי*, "and glorification *under* my tongue." Not *on* the tongue but *beneath* it. Rashi reads *רוֹמָם* as a noun and glosses precisely:

רוֹמָמוֹת שְׁלוֹ מוֹכֵן תַּחַת לְשׁוֹנִי לְהוֹצִיאָו בִּפֶּה

"His exaltation is *ready* under my tongue, to be brought out through the mouth," explicitly citing Job 20:12, where evil is savored *לְשׁוֹנוֹ תַּחַת*, "hidden under his tongue." Praise here is stored, poised, held in reserve — pre-formed liturgical readiness, present *before* the answer, not generated by it. Malbim sharpens the sequence: the worshipper called to God with his mouth, and *more than that* — the exaltation was already beneath the tongue, deeper and more inward, before the words emerged.

The under-the-tongue idiom is worth pursuing, because the Psalter usually stores something else there. Psalm 10:7: *תַּחַת לְשׁוֹנוֹ עֲמָל וָאָוֶן*, "under his tongue are mischief and iniquity"; Psalm 140:4: *חֲמַת עֶקְשׁוֹב תַּחַת שְׁפָתֵימוֹ*, "the venom of the viper is under their lips." The wicked hide malice in that cavity. The psalmist fills the very same hiding-place with stored *praise* — and then, in the next verse, certifies it clean of exactly the *אָוֶן*, "iniquity," that Psalm 10:7 keeps there. One gesture across two verses: occupy the wicked's cache of hidden evil with poised glorification, then declare it free of the word that usually lives there.

Verse 18

אָוֶן אִם־רָאִיתִי בְּלִבִּי; לֹא יִשְׁמַע אֱלֹהִי:

The moral hinge, and the word is fronted for maximum weight: *אָוֶן*, "iniquity," stands first, before the conditional even begins — "iniquity, had I seen it in my heart. *רָאָה בְּלִב*, to see in the heart," means to consciously entertain, tolerate, cherish inner evil — not a slip of behavior but moral assent. The condition complements the sacrifices of vv. 13–15: the bulls and rams are void without inner integrity. The prophetic critique of empty cult stands behind it (Isa 1:11–17). The commentators press further into the psychology of intention. Radak: even the *thought* of iniquity, had God "counted" it, would have blocked the prayer — but

הַמַּחְשְׁבָה רָעָה אֵין הַקָּדוֹשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא מִצְרֶפָה לְמַעֲשֶׂה

"an evil thought God does not join to the deed." The Talmud (Kiddushin 40a) builds a whole doctrine of intention on this half-verse: a good thought is credited as a deed, but a bare evil thought that bears no fruit is not — proof-texted from *אָוֶן אִם־רָאִיתִי בְּלִבִּי*.

Then the crux that the essay flagged: *לֹא יִשְׁמַע אֱלֹהִי*, "the Lord would not hear." This is the *only* occurrence of *אֱלֹהִי* in an otherwise uniformly Elohistic psalm — every other divine reference is *אֱלֹהִים*. The title *אֱלֹהִי* surfaces at the precise moment the worshipper turns

inward to examine his own heart. Whether this is a scribal remnant that escaped the Elohist redaction or a deliberate theological choice, the effect is the same: the shift away from the psalm's usual Elohim attaches itself to the ethics of being heard.

Shakespeare dramatized this exact mechanism — the barrier an unrepentant heart raises against prayer — in *Hamlet* (c. 1600). King Claudius, having murdered his brother, kneels to pray and cannot:

Bow, stubborn knees; and, heart with strings of steel, / Be soft as sinews of the new-born babe!

...

My words fly up, my thoughts remain below. / Words without thoughts never to heaven go.

The psalm celebrates the *alignment* of heart and tongue that lets prayer ascend; Shakespeare stages its tragic separation. Claudius's couplet is almost a commentary on v. 18 — the אָנן בִּלְבָב, the iniquity in the heart, that keeps even a kneeling king unheard. Both texts share a theology in which prayer is not a verbal transaction but a moral one: the mouth is only heard when the heart consents.

Verse 19

אָכֵן שָׁמַע אֱלֹקִים; הִקְשִׁיב בְּקוֹל תְּפִלָּתִי:

The reversal detonates on one word. אָכֵן is among Hebrew's strongest adversative-affirmatives — "but *indeed*, surely, against all expectation." It is Jacob waking at Bethel: אָכֵן יְיָ ה' בַּמָּקוֹם הַזֶּה, "surely the LORD is in this place — and I did not know" (Gen 28:16). After the conditional threat of v. 18 (לֹא יִשְׁמַע, "He would not hear"), אָכֵן shatters it: God *did* hear. Ibn Ezra glosses by the parallel הִדְבָּר הַזֶּה, "indeed, the thing is known."

And the single feared verb of v. 18 is now doubled and intensified. God שָׁמַע, "heard," and הִקְשִׁיב, "gave attentive ear" — an active inclining of the ear, leaning in, as in שָׁמַע לְקוֹל, "attend to the sound of my cry" (Ps 5:3). Not passive reception but focused attention: the opposite of the silence threatened one verse earlier. The object closes the acoustic frame the psalm opened at v. 8: קוֹל תְּהִלָּתוֹ, "the sound of my prayer," answers קוֹל תְּפִלָּתִי, "the sound of His praise" — the one-consonant slide from communal *praise* to individual *prayer* completed, and the prayer heard.

There is a mirror-psalm worth naming. Psalm 81, another Elohist composition, shares this psalm's rarest vocabulary — הִרְיֵעוּ לְאֱלֹקִים, "shout to God" (81:2 // 66:1); the enemy-verb יִכְהַשׁוּ (81:16 // 66:3); the testing-root בָּחַן (81:8 אֶבְחַנְךָ // 66:10); שָׁמַע with קוֹל. But 81 runs

the hearing the other way. Its climax is divine complaint: וְלֹא־שָׁמַע עַמִּי לְקוֹלִי, "but My people did not listen to My voice" (81:12). Psalm 66's climax is the answer: שָׁמַע אֱלֹהִים... בְּקוֹל תְּפִלָּתִי, "God heard... the sound of my prayer." Two psalms from the same lexicon, the vector of hearing reversed — in one, humanity fails to hear the tested God; in the other, the tested worshipper is heard by God.

Verse 20

בְּרוּךְ אֱלֹהִים אֲשֶׁר לֹא־הִסִּיר תְּפִלָּתִי; וְחִסְדּוֹ מֵאֵתִי:

The closing blessing, and it works by yoking two very different objects under one verb — a construction where a single word governs two terms it does not fit equally. לֹא הִסִּיר, "He did not turn aside," takes both תְּפִלָּתִי, "my prayer," and חִסְדּוֹ, "His steadfast love." But one *withdraws* love; what does it mean to "turn aside" a prayer? The idiom (סִוֵּר, "remove, cause to depart") implies that prayer is a standing object *before* God — not merely spoken and gone but present, persistent, capable of being either kept or dismissed. Rashi splits it cleanly:

לֹא הִסִּיר תְּפִלָּתִי מִלִּפְנֵי, וְחִסְדּוֹ לֹא הִסִּיר מֵאֵתִי

"He did not remove my prayer from before Him, and His *hesed* He did not remove from me." Metzudat David notes that the negation "did not remove my prayer" specifically counters the worry of v. 18 — despite the possible inner iniquity, the prayer was not dismissed.

The final word is חֶסֶד, "steadfast, covenantal love" — and its placement carries quiet weight. *hesed* is overwhelmingly a *YHWH*-covenant term, yet here it crowns an Elohistic psalm, as if the covenant-relational register the editorial convention suppresses insists on the last word anyway. And מֵאֵתִי, "from me / from beside me," locates that *hesed* in close proximity — not abstract love but love kept near. Malbim makes the theological maximum of the double negative: God acted

לֹא עַל־פִּי הַדִּין... רַק מִצַּד חֶסְדּוֹ הַגָּדוֹל

"not by strict justice but out of His great *hesed*," even though the worshipper was undeserving. The Talmud (Berakhot 5a) enlists the verse to define שְׁלֵ אֶהְבֶּה, "sufferings of love": afflictions that do not interrupt prayer, proof-texted precisely from

בְּרוּךְ אֱלֹהִים אֲשֶׁר לֹא־הִסִּיר תְּפִלָּתִי

— bringing the psalm's refining-theodicy full circle, since the ordeal that assayed the community (v. 10) is now the very love that never withdrew.

Lea Goldberg's "Teach Me, My God" offers the gentlest possible coda to a psalm that ends by defining answered prayer as *rescue*:

לְמַדְנִי, אֱלֹהִי, בְּרוּךְ יְהוָה תִּפְלֵל / עַל סוּד עֵלֶה קָמַל, עַל נֹגַהּ פְּרִי בָשִׁיל

"Teach me, my God, to bless and pray / on the mystery of a withered leaf, on the glow of ripe fruit."

Psalm 66 concludes with God not turning away a desperate plea made בְּצַר־לִי, "in my distress." Goldberg quietly redefines what the answered prayer might be: not dramatic deliverance from fire and water, but the sensory capacity, in the aftermath of survival, to notice the glow of ripe fruit — grace expanded even to "the freedom to fail." The psalmist blesses God for the rescue; Goldberg blesses Him for the ordinary seeing that survival makes possible. Both end where Psalm 66 ends — with a בְּרוּךְ, a blessing — but the psalm looks back at the crisis it escaped, and Goldberg looks around at the world it was returned to.

Methodological & Bibliographical Summary

Research & Data Inputs

Psalm Verses Analyzed: 20

LXX (Septuagint) Verses Reviewed: 20

Phonetic Transcriptions Generated: 20

Lexicon Entries (BDB/Klein) Reviewed: 25

Traditional Commentaries Reviewed: 106 (Ibn Ezra (19); Malbim (11); Meiri (20); Metzudat David (18); Radak (18); Rashi (16); Torah Temimah (4))

Concordance Entries Reviewed: 701

Figurative Concordance Matches Reviewed: 350 (battle shout (50); fire (50); foot (50); net (50); refining (50); sea (50); tongue (50))

Rabbi Jonathan Sacks References Reviewed: 7

Similar Psalms Analyzed: 5 (Psalms 141, 18, 81, 56, 69)

Deep Web Research: Yes

Literary Echoes Research: Yes

Sections Trimmed for Context: None

Master Editor Prompt Size: 315,433 characters

Models Used

Structural Analysis (Macro): claude-opus-4-8

Verse Discovery (Micro): claude-sonnet-4-6

Liturgical Librarian: gpt-5.1

Figurative Curator: gpt-5.4

Cross-Verse Synthesis Discovery: claude-opus-4-8

Commentary (Master Writer): claude-opus-4-8

Citation Verifier Filter: gpt-5.1

Copy Editor: gpt-5.4

Literary Echoes (Passes 1 & 2 — Generation): gemini-3.1-pro-preview

Literary Echoes (Passes 3 & 4 — Verify + Reconstruct): gpt-5.4

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